mean is that ethnic groups different from the core group have no right to exist. Indeed, most modern states have managed to respond to these complexities in a decent and humane way. Unfortunately this is not the case in Myanmar. Here, the dominant narrative of many Burmese about the Rohingyas is one of illegitimate ‘invasion’ by a threatening ‘outsider’.

This chapter has made it clear that for a long period, the history and ethnicity of Arakan developed separately to that of the rest of Burma. Political integration is relatively recent and all the evidence is that the Rohingyas were living in Arakan even before the Buddhist Rakhine arrived.

This is not to say that the nuances of early history should have any legitimacy in determining who is a citizen of a modern state. No matter what the Myanmar authorities have to say about the supposed history of Rakhine and the Rohingyas, there is no getting away from the fact that no state can render stateless, as a matter of policy, people born in its territory, under the UN Charter.[88] If a person is born on the territory of a country, and has no other legal citizenship, then they must be given citizenship by that country. The Rohingyas are Burmese by birth and according to international law. Where their distant ancestors may have come from and why is entirely irrelevant. And no amount of history, veridical or fabricated, can change that basic fact. No amount of history can then justify any attempt at ethnic cleansing.

Unfortunately, the pre-colonial history of Burma does matter, insofar as one version of it forms a major justification for the persecution of the Rohingyas. The reality in today’s Myanmar means it is very important to look at these attempts at rewriting history in order to understand the mindset of the aggressors and see exactly how this phenomenon builds into a precursor to genocide. And it is here also that the international community can bring a lot to the table and provide the necessary objective analysis of the history of the region in order to refute the falsified narrative used by those who call for the expulsion of the Rohingyas from Myanmar. The average citizen of Myanmar has a right to know their own history, and has a right not to be deceived by the absurd propositions of Buddhist extremists in Myanmar.